VIABILITY ASSESSMENT · BUSINESS PLAN · ACTION PLAN

MuddleAndMix.bar: is there a business here?

Prepared for Richard Bailey, Oct 12, 2026. Based on a read of the `richoncode/muddleandmix` repo (last commit Sep 21, 2026), the live landing page, and web research (sources at the end). Labels: SOURCE means a cited fact, ESTIMATE means an assumption I made, and REPO means I checked it in the code.

VERDICT

Niche hobby, with one 90-day test to pivot

Not a "go" as a venture. A cheap, time-boxed "test" to see if it can pay for itself.

Executive summary

- **The general home-bar app market is crowded and cheap.** At least 9 live apps already do "track bottles → what can I make", and several also do AI bottle scanning, for **$0–$6/month**. Examples: Mixel ($14.99/yr), Home Bar Hero (free core), BottleSnaps ($6/mo), Elixiary, BarShelf, Cocktail Flow, and the open-source Bar Assistant. A plain "another home-bar tracker" will not get noticed.
- **The bar/restaurant inventory market pays well, but it is the wrong fight for a solo builder.** It pays $75–$299 per location per month, but buyers expect POS integrations, pour costing, and multi-user counting. Backbar also gives away a free tier.
- **The best opening is hosting.** MuddleAndMix's strongest features are party planning, the shopping list, and the shareable guest menu. Two groups could use them: **home party hosts** (free tier that spreads itself, plus a ~$25/yr Pro) and **mobile/event bartenders** (a ~$19/mo "Host Pro"). Competitors here (Baraxis $29/mo, EventPro) are fewer and newer.
- **Unit economics only work if free-tier AI use is limited.** The app uses gpt-4o for scans and imports, at roughly **$0.19–$0.27 per active user per month** (estimate). At a 3% paid conversion, each $25/yr payer would carry about $100/yr of free-user AI cost. A free-tier cap and moving bulk calls to gpt-4o-mini (about 16× cheaper per token) are required.
- **Some security and multi-user problems must be fixed before strangers use it.** Any signed-in user can edit or delete the shared recipes. Some inventory endpoints have no sign-in check. AI use has no limits. The free barcode API allows only 100 lookups a day for everyone. With fixes and the holiday party season, a 90-day test costs under $200 cash. The **Day-90 gate is Jan 10, 2027**.

$0

Revenue and outside users today (as you told me)

~$12/mo

Fixed run cost in the model: hosting estimate plus a placeholder domain cost ESTIMATE

$316

Base-case MRR at month 12; most of it from Host Pro ESTIMATE

3 actions

Top next steps: fix security, cap and cheapen AI, run a holiday party-menu test

CONTEXT

What MuddleAndMix actually is today REPO

I checked this in the code. A few points differ from the brief: the app is **React + Vite on the front end with an Express 5 back end**, not Next.js. It uses Drizzle ORM on Postgres, Auth.js Google sign-in, and is deployed to Cloud Run behind Firebase Hosting (scaffolded in PR #1, Sep 17, 2026).

Confirmed features

- Bottle inventory: bottles with size and amount remaining, plus a buy list (`bottles`, `buy_list` tables)
- Add a bottle by **UPC barcode** (UPCitemdb free trial API, cleaned up with gpt-4o-mini), **AI photo scan** (gpt-4o vision), or manual entry
- Recipe import from **URL** (page text capped at 15k chars, then gpt-4o), **pasted text**, and **recipe photo**; plus AI "Discover" (60 names) and import in batches of 10
- "What can I make" with **substitution groups** (identical vs. variation, with quantity multipliers)
- **Plan** page: pick drinks and servings to get a shopping list, plus "Convenient Additions" (the single bottle that unlocks the most drinks)
- **Shareable guest menu** (`/guest/:token`); guests can save favorites in their browser
- "Serve" a drink to subtract pours from bottles; 9 visual themes; bar name, banner, and tagline
- Feedback button, a hidden admin page, counter-only telemetry, seeded library (landing page: "100+ recipes")

Launch blockers before inviting strangers

- **Shared recipe library with no owner check:** `PATCH/DELETE /api/recipes/:id` and the ingredient edit routes only check that someone is signed in. Any Google user could edit or delete everyone's recipes. Admin mode exists only in the browser (15 taps on the banner).
- `PATCH /api/ingredients/:id/stock` and `/details` have **no sign-in check** and write to a single `ingredients` table shared by all users.
- Any signed-in user can change substitution groups and read feedback and telemetry.
- **No per-user limits on gpt-4o endpoints**, so one user or script could run up OpenAI costs.
- The UPCitemdb free tier allows **100 requests a day and 6 a minute**, shared by every user coming from the Cloud Run IP.
- The Allrecipes "402" error is the publisher charging AI crawlers (Cloudflare pay-per-crawl). Don't try to get around it; push users to paste text instead.
- Telemetry only stores total counts. There are no per-user events, so you can't measure activation or retention yet.
- I didn't see a privacy policy, terms, or a 21+ age confirmation on the landing page.

PART 1

Viability assessment

Market signals

SIGNAL	WHAT IT SAYS	READ
US spirits 2025 (DISCUS)	Supplier revenue −2.2% to $36.4B; volume +1.9%, driven by ready-to-drink (RTD) cocktails (+16.4% to $3.8B). Excluding RTDs, revenue −4%. SOURCE	Headwind Mixing at home from bottles is not a growing category
Gallup, July 2025	54% of US adults say they drink, a record low in nearly 90 years of polling. SOURCE	Headwind Mocktail and low-ABV support is worth having
r/cocktails	About 367K–437K members, depending on the tracker; the community says most are home hobbyists. SOURCE	Reachable A concentrated, free channel (follow the self-promo rules)
US Bars & Nightclubs (IBISWorld)	69,948 businesses in 2026; Cocktail Bars: 29,911 (2024). SOURCE	Large but served Many incumbent tools
Mixel (category leader, iOS)	4.7★ from about 1.1K reviews; third-party estimate of about **$7K/month revenue** and under 1K monthly downloads (Adapty, not official). SOURCE	Low ceiling Even the leader looks like a small business

Segment scoring

Scores run 1–5, where 5 is best for MuddleAndMix. Weights: willingness to pay 25%, competition (5 = less) 20%, fit with today's product 25%, solo reachability 20%, ops/compliance burden (5 = light) 10%. The scores are my judgment, based on the research below. ESTIMATE

SEGMENT	WILL PAY	COMPETITION	FIT	REACH	BURDEN	WEIGHTED	CALL
Home party hosts (holidays, birthdays, game nights)	3	3	5	3	4	**3.60**	Primary wedge
Mobile / event bartenders (weddings, private events)	4	3	3	4	3	**3.45**	Revenue wedge
General home enthusiasts	2	1	5	4	4	3.15	Top of funnel only
Spirits brands / retailers (affiliate, sponsorship)	3	3	2	1	3	2.35	Later, needs an audience
Small bars / restaurants (inventory)	4	1	2	2	2	2.30	Avoid
Bar managers / hospitality groups	5	1	1	1	1	2.00	Avoid

Competitive landscape (each verified to exist; prices as found Oct 2026)

PRODUCT	SEGMENT	PRICING FOUND	OVERLAP WITH MUDDLEANDMIX
Mixel	Home, iOS	Free; $1.99/mo, $14.99/yr, $49.99 lifetime; recipe packs	High: "what can I make", Maximizer (best next bottle), AI "Bart", shopping list
Home Bar Hero	Home, AI	Free core; $2.99/mo, $24.99/yr; lifetime shown as $49.99 on one page and $99.99 on another	Very high: AI multi-bottle scan, Smart Buy, **Party Host Mode (QR)**, shared household bars
BottleSnaps	Home, web PWA	Free (3 scans, 10 bottles); $6/mo	High: AI shelf scan, buy-next, browser-based like MuddleAndMix
Elixiary	Home, AI	€3 / €5.50 / €11 / €25 per month	High: barcode (OpenFoodFacts), mark-as-made subtracts stock
BarShelf	Home, iOS	Free up to 10 bottles; $3.99/mo, $39.99/yr	Medium: inventory, AI bartender
Cocktail Flow	Home, iOS	$4.99/mo, $24.99/yr	Medium: cabinet, makeable drinks
Cocktail Party	Home, iOS	Conflicting reports: $4.99 one-time vs. $2.99/mo	Medium: ingredient search, shopping list
Highball	Home recipe cards	Free plus tips; promotes Studio Neat products	Low: personal recipe cards
Bar Assistant	Home/pro, open source	Free to self-host (MIT)	High for technical users: inventory, menus, costing
Barsys	Hardware	$375 machine; free app	Low. "BarSys" is a cocktail machine, not inventory software
Backbar	Bars	**$0 Basic**; $79/$99 Essential; $129/$149 Pro per location	Free B2B tier rules out a "cheap bar inventory" pitch
Partender	Bars	$299/mo, or $199/mo billed annually	Visual bottle counting
WISK	Bars / hotels	$249/mo per venue + $750 setup	POS, invoices, Bluetooth scale

BinWise	Bars / wine	Quote only	Enterprise
Sculpture Hospitality	Bars + consultants	Self-service from $199/mo + setup; franchise model	Service-heavy
Bevager	Bar back office	From $99.99/user/mo (listing)	Purchasing / invoices
Baraxis	Mobile bartenders	$29/mo or $199/yr	CRM, scheduling, recipes, stock planning
EventPro Bartender	Mobile bartenders	Not published on the homepage	Event calculators and shopping lists, made by a mobile bar company

Positioning

> Home-bar apps compete on **recipe count and AI scanning**, and that race is already lost on price. MuddleAndMix's real difference is a combination: a **branded, shareable bar menu** (9 themes, banner, bar name, guest favorites), **party planning by number of servings**, and **"buy one bottle, unlock the most drinks."** Home Bar Hero has a Party Host Mode, so this is not a moat. It is a focus. The pitch: *"Your bar's menu, made for the party. Guests pick from what you can actually pour, and you get the exact shopping list."*

Unit economics ESTIMATE

AI cost per action (models from the code)

ACTION	MODEL	≈ $/ACTION
Bottle photo scan	gpt-4o	$0.006
UPC lookup clean-up	gpt-4o-mini	$0.0002
Recipe import from URL	gpt-4o	$0.020
Paste text / photo import	gpt-4o	$0.013
Discover 60 names	gpt-4o	$0.008
Import 10 recipes	gpt-4o	$0.052
Per active user per month (6 scans, 6 UPC, 6 imports, 1 discover + batch)		**$0.19**

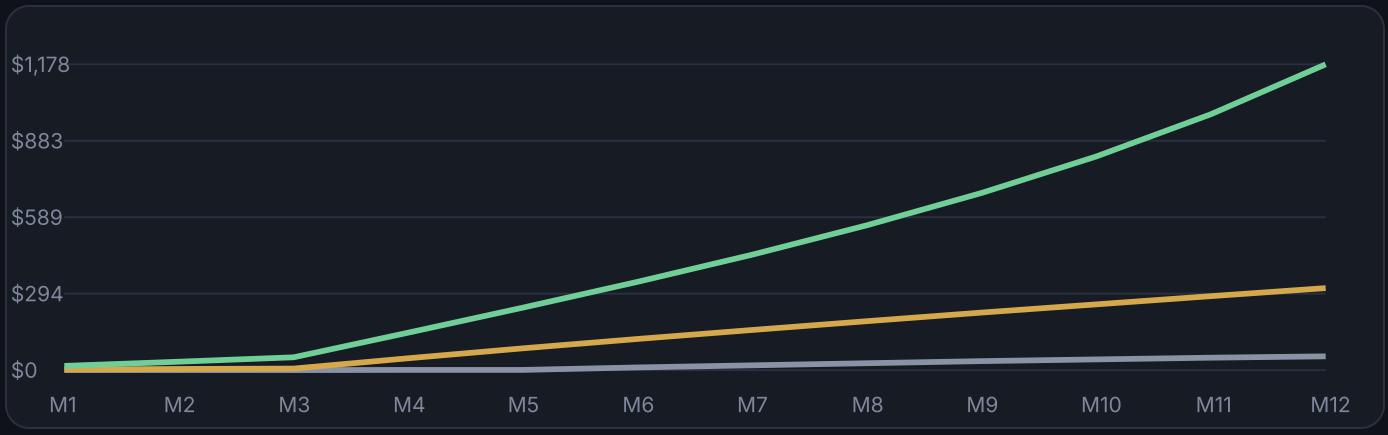
Token counts are estimates. Prices are $2.50/$10 per million tokens (gpt-4o) and $0.15/$0.60 (gpt-4o-mini), from OpenAI. The base model adds a 40% buffer, giving $0.27.

What that means

- **Home Pro at $24.99/yr:** Stripe takes about $1.02, and AI for the payer is about $3.24/yr, leaving roughly **$20.70/yr** of contribution.
- **The freemium trap:** at 3% conversion, each payer carries about 32 free users. At $0.27/mo each, that's about **$104/yr of AI cost per payer**, so the home tier loses money as built.
- **Fix:** cap free AI at about 5 actions a month, and move discover, import-names, and text parsing to gpt-4o-mini (about $0.012 per user per month). Then 1 payer can carry about 140 free users.
- **Hosting:** the Cloud Run free tier (2M requests, 180k vCPU-seconds per month) and Neon free tier (100 CU-hours and 1 GB per project) should cover the first few hundred users. SOURCE
- **Customer acquisition cost (CAC), guessed:** paid social at $2–$10 per sign-up is $67–$333 per payer at 3% conversion. That is far above home-tier lifetime value (about $30), so **no paid ads for the consumer tier**. Host Pro lifetime value is about $19 × ~20 months ≈ $380, so a CAC under $100 is tolerable there. ESTIMATE

Scenarios (from the .xlsx; every input is an assumption)

METRIC	CONSERVATIVE	BASE	UPSIDE
Month-12 active users	27	329	2,580
Month-12 Home Pro paying users	0	10	129
Month-12 Host/Pro accounts	3	15	31
Month-12 MRR (total revenue in M12)	$53	$316	$1,178
12-month revenue	$234	$1,680	$5,494
12-month costs	$540	$1,418	$4,516
12-month net	−$307	$263	$979
12-month AI cost	$141	$580	$2,343



Conservative: M12 MRR $53 Base: M12 MRR $316 Upside: M12 MRR $1,178

In the base case, about 89% of year-1 revenue comes from Host Pro. That is the main finding: the consumer tier is for growth and word of mouth, and the semi-pro tier is what can pay the bills.

Risks

RISK	SEVERITY	MITIGATION
Crowded, cheap category; users don't switch	High	Lead with party hosting and branded menus, not "track your bar"
Security and multi-user bugs (above) if strangers sign up	High	Fix as P0 before any public post
AI cost runaway or abuse	High	Per-user daily quota, a hard monthly limit in the OpenAI dashboard, cheaper models
Data dependencies (UPCitemdb limit, publishers blocking AI)	Med	Cache UPC results in Postgres, fall back to OpenFoodFacts, prefer pasted text
Alcohol category headwinds (Gallup, DISCUS)	Med	First-class mocktail / zero-proof support (already a discover chip)
Solo founder time; day job at Quintar (IP/moonlighting terms)	Med	Check your employment agreement; time-box to about 6 hrs/week
Alcohol marketing and app store rules	Med	See regulatory notes

Regulatory notes (not legal advice)

- **Apple:** frequent alcohol references can lead to an **18+** rating under the 2025 age ratings, and developers may choose a higher rating. Expect 18+ if you ever ship a native app. Apple
- **Google Play:** apps must not encourage underage drinking or glamorize excessive drinking. Apps that facilitate alcohol sales must be age-restricted. Play policy
- **Paid social:** Meta requires **21+ targeting** for alcohol ads in the US. Meta
- **Brand partnerships:** the DISCUS Code (2025) asks that at least **73.8%** of the audience be of legal drinking age. Brands will ask you about it. DISCUS
- **Recipes:** in the US, a plain list of ingredients and simple directions is not protected by copyright, but descriptive text and photos are. Keep paraphrasing, credit sources, and don't scrape sites that block it. USCO Circular 33
- MuddleAndMix doesn't sell alcohol, so it doesn't need a liquor license. Affiliate links should go to licensed retailers (ReserveBar's program is reported at about 4% with a 30-day cookie). Get legal advice before any per-sale deal paid by a brand, because state "tied-house" laws vary.
- Add a 21+ confirmation, a privacy policy, and terms before going public. Google sign-in means you store names and emails.

Kill / continue criteria

GATE	CONTINUE IF	KILL / STAY HOBBY IF
Day 30 — Nov 11, 2026	≥25 outside sign-ups with ≥5 bottles; ≥10 menus shared to guests	<10 activated users after 2 posts and 10 personal invites
Day 60 — Dec 11, 2026	Week-4 retention ≥20%; ≥10 paid founding members	Retention <10% and <3 payments
Day 90 — Jan 10, 2027	≥3 paying Host Pro pilots and ≥$100 MRR	0–1 pilots and <$25 MRR → freeze features and keep it running for yourself at about $0
Always	AI + hosting <30% of revenue	>60% for 2 months → tighten caps or drop the feature

Pivot path: if hosts love the guest menu but no one pays, go Host Pro only. If no one engages, keep it as a portfolio project; it's still a strong demo of your full-stack and AI work.

PART 2

Business plan

Positioning statement

For **people who host drinks**, from Friendsgiving hosts to mobile bartenders, MuddleAndMix is the **party-ready bar menu** that shows guests only what you can actually pour and gives you the exact shopping list. Recipe apps are built for browsing alone. MuddleAndMix is built for **the night you're serving other people**.

Target customers

- **Primary (free → Home Pro):** adults 25–45 with 10–40 bottles who host 4+ times a year. They post in r/cocktails and r/homebar and want to impress guests without overbuying.
- **Paying wedge (Host Pro):** 1–5-person mobile bar businesses doing weddings and private events. Their pain is per-event menus, quantity math, and shopping lists, often kept in spreadsheets (EventPro's own story describes this).
- **Not now:** bars needing POS-linked inventory.

Pricing tiers (web-first through Stripe; no app-store cut)

TIER	PRICE	INCLUDES	BENCHMARK LOGIC
Free	$0	Unlimited manual bottles, full library, What-Can-I-Make, 1 live party menu, 5 AI actions/mo, "Made with MuddleAndMix" footer on shared menus	Matches Home Bar Hero and Mixel free tiers; the footer is the growth loop
Home Pro	$2.99/mo or **$24.99/yr** (founding: $19.99/yr, locked)	Fair-use AI (about 100/mo), unlimited party menus, all themes and custom banner, guest drink requests, export	In line with Cocktail Flow and Home Bar Hero ($24.99/yr); above Mixel ($14.99), below BarShelf ($39.99)
Host Pro	**$19/mo** or $190/yr (founding pilots: $9/mo for 6 mo)	Client-branded menus (no MM branding), per-event serving/batch calculator by guest count, PDF and QR menus, multiple concurrent events, client share links	Below Baraxis ($29/mo) and well below Backbar Essential ($79); complements a CRM rather than replacing one

Go-to-market channels (ranked for a solo builder)

#	CHANNEL	WHY	COST
1	Guest-menu growth loop (every shared menu ends with "Make your own bar menu →")	Each host shows the product to 5–20 guests; free	$0, about 1 evening
2	Communities: r/cocktails (~400K), r/homebar, Discord/Facebook cocktail groups; "I built this" plus a holiday party-menu angle	Concentrated home enthusiasts	$0, time
3	Direct outreach to mobile bartenders (local directories, Facebook groups, wedding vendor lists, Instagram DMs)	The paying wedge; small numbers are enough	$0, 2 hrs/week
4	SEO from the seeded library: "/what-can-i-make-with/gin-lime" and "/party-menu/friendsgiving" pages (server-side OG tags already exist)	Compounds over time; reuses existing data	$0, build once
5	Product Hunt / Hacker News "Show HN" launch after the fixes	One-time spike, plus feedback	$0
6	Short videos ("scan → menu → shopping list in 60s") on IG/TikTok, aimed at a 21+ audience	Visual product; themes look good	$0–$50 tests
7	Paid ads (Meta, 21+ only)	Only for Host Pro, capped at $150/mo	Small tests only

12-month milestones

WHEN	MILESTONE	TARGET ESTIMATE
Oct–Nov 2026	Security fixes, AI caps, analytics, legal pages; holiday party-menu launch	25 activated outside users; 10 shared menus
Dec 2026	Stripe founding-member link; guest drink requests	10 paid; week-4 retention ≥20%
Jan 2027 (Day 90)	Host Pro pilots; go / kill review	3 paying pilots; MRR ≥$100
Feb–Mar 2027	Host Pro v1: branded PDF/QR menus, batch calculator; 50 SEO pages	8 Host Pro; 1,000 visitors/mo
Apr–Jun 2027	Wedding-season push to mobile bartenders; testimonials; referral credit	12–15 Host Pro; MRR about $250–$300
Jul–Sep 2027	Year-1 review: scale (LLC, native wrapper, Neon paid plan) or maintain	Base case about $316 MRR at month 12

Simple financial model

See `muddleandmix-financial-model.xlsx`. It has three scenario tabs that share the same formulas, a yellow-cell assumptions tab, an AI unit-cost tab, a benchmarks tab with links, and a kill/continue tracker. Base case: **about $1.7K revenue and $1.4K costs in year 1** (including $600 of optional marketing), cash-flow positive from month 6, about $316 MRR at month 12. Your time is not counted, so treat this as a self-funding side project, not a salary.

PART 3

Action plan: 30 / 60 / 90 days

Each item is small enough to do alone in evenings. Priority: P0 blocks everything, P1 is the core experiment, P2 is nice to have.

Days 1–30 (Oct 12 → Nov 11, 2026): make it safe, measurable, and party-ready

PRI	TASK / EXPERIMENT	SUCCESS METRIC	EFFORT
P0	Lock down multi-user access: per-user recipes (or a server-side `isAdmin` check on shared recipe, ingredient, and substitution writes); add auth and per-user scoping to `/ingredients/:id/stock` and `/details`; restrict feedback and telemetry reads to admins	A second Google account cannot change any data it doesn't own (manual test)	2–3 evenings
P0	AI guardrails: per-user daily and monthly quota table; a hard monthly budget in OpenAI; move discover, import-names, and parse-text to gpt-4o-mini (A/B 20 recipes for quality)	AI cost per active user ≤$0.05/mo; no quality regressions you'd notice	1–2 evenings
P0	Cache UPC lookups in Postgres and fall back to OpenFoodFacts; show a friendly "paste the recipe text" message on 402s	Zero failed barcode adds caused by the rate limit	1 evening
P0	Per-user analytics events: signup, bottle_added, recipe_imported, menu_shared, guest_view, shopping_list_created, upgrade_clicked	You can compute activation (≥5 bottles) and week-1 retention	1 evening
P0	21+ confirmation, privacy policy, terms (generated, then reviewed); a "drink responsibly" footer	Pages live and linked from the landing page	2 hrs
P1	**Exp 1: Holiday party menu.** Landing variant "Plan your Friendsgiving / holiday bar in 5 minutes"; invite 10 friends who host	≥5 hosts share a menu; ≥30 guest views	1 evening + messages
P1	**Exp 2: Community launch.** One honest post each in r/cocktails (check self-promo rules) and r/homebar, with a 60-second screen recording	≥25 outside sign-ups with ≥5 bottles	2 hrs
P2	**Exp 3: 5 user sessions.** Watch people add their bar over Zoom or in person	Time to first "what can I make" <3 min; top 3 friction points logged	3 hrs

Days 31–60 (Nov 12 → Dec 11, 2026): test willingness to pay

PRI	TASK / EXPERIMENT	SUCCESS METRIC	EFFORT
P1	**Exp 4: Founding Home Pro.** A Stripe Payment Link for $19.99/yr, shown on hitting the AI cap and in the theme picker (switch the flag on manually at first)	≥10 purchases, or upgrade click-through ≥5% of actives	1 evening
P1	**Exp 5: Guest drink requests.** Guests tap "I'd like this"; the host sees a live queue	≥40% of shared menus receive ≥1 request	2 evenings
P1	**Exp 6: Mobile bartender discovery.** 15 personal DMs/emails offering a free branded menu and shopping list for their next event	5 calls booked; 3 use it at a real event	2 hrs/week
P2	**Exp 7: SEO pages.** 30 static "what can I make with X + Y" and "party menu for N guests" pages from seed data	Pages indexed in Search Console; first organic sign-ups	2 evenings

Days 61–90 (Dec 12, 2026 → Jan 10, 2027): first B2B revenue and decision

PRI	TASK / EXPERIMENT	SUCCESS METRIC	EFFORT
P1	**Exp 8: Host Pro pilot.** Charge interested bartenders $9/mo founding (6 months), then $19. Features: no MM branding, PDF/QR menu, guest-count calculator	≥3 paying pilots	3 evenings
P2	**Exp 9: Affiliate on the shopping list.** Apply to a licensed retailer program (e.g., ReserveBar) and add "buy" links	Click-through ≥3% of generated lists; any commission	1 evening
P2	**Exp 10: Show HN / Product Hunt** once the above is stable	≥100 sign-ups in launch week	half a day
P0	**Day-90 review (Jan 10, 2027)** against the kill/continue table; write a 1-page retro and fill in the xlsx "Kill-Continue" actuals	A clear decision: scale / Host-Pro-only / hobby	2 hrs

OPEN

Questions only Richard can answer

1. Does your **Quintar employment agreement** allow a paid side business, and who owns IP you create on your own time?
2. What is your **weekly time budget** (this plan assumes about 6 hours), and how much cash are you willing to risk (the plan assumes ≤$200 over 90 days)?
3. Do you want this to be **a business, a portfolio piece, or a tool for you and friends**? The right answer changes the verdict.
4. Should recipes be **shared globally or private per user**? Today they're global and editable by any signed-in user.
5. What does the **.bar domain actually cost to renew**, and what is current OpenAI spend per month? The model uses an $80/yr placeholder.
6. Do you know any **mobile bartenders or event hosts** personally? The B2B wedge depends on the first 3 pilots.
7. Web-only PWA, or do you want native apps (with an 18+ rating and a 15% app-store commission)?
8. Are you comfortable forming an **LLC** and taking payments in your name before revenue?

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